

and awesome above all **those who surround him?**

⁸ Yahweh, **Elohim of hosts**, who is like you, O mighty Yahweh?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 82:1, 6-7 NASB*

¹ God has taken his place in **the divine council**;
in the midst of the *elohim* he holds judgment. ...

⁶ I said, "You are *elohim*,
sons of the Most High, all of you;

⁷ nevertheless, like humans you shall die,
and fall like any prince."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This group of spiritual beings called "the divine council" (Ps. 82:1, 89:7) is also called "the host of heaven" (1 Kgs. 22:19) or "holy ones" (Ps. 89:5, 7; Job 5:1; Zech. 14:5; Dan. 8:24). These members of the divine council are the inhabitants of the spiritual realm. They are images of God's glory in the heavenly realm and correspond with humans in the earthly realm.

The Meaning of "Sons of ____" or "Daughters of ____"

In Hebrew, the plural phrase "sons of ____" is a figure of speech that means "members of the class/group of ____." The bold word is used as a descriptor of a class.

"Sons of **Bethlehem**" = inhabitants of Bethlehem (Ezra 2:21)

"Daughters of **the city**" = female residents of a city (Lam. 3:51)

"Daughters of **Edom**" = inhabitants of Edom (Ezek. 16:57)

"Sons of **Egypt**" = inhabitants of Egypt (Ezek. 16:26)

"Sons of **the prophets**" = members of Elisha's prophetic group (2 Kgs. 2:15)

"Sons of **humanity**" = members of the human race (2 Sam. 7:14)

"Daughters of **the song**" = female singers (Ecc. 12:4)

In each case, the plural "sons/daughters of ____" refers to people who are members of a group or class that qualifies their identity in some way. In Genesis 6:1-2 we find:

- "Daughters of humanity" = human daughters
- "Sons of *Elohim*" = *Elohim* beings, i.e., spiritual beings

Genesis 6:1 draws a strong contrast between the "daughters of humanity" and the "sons of *Elohim*" because the point at issue is the violation of boundaries between human and divine.

Other Interpretations of the Sons of *Elohim*

Some interpreters argue that the sons of *Elohim* in Genesis 6 are human beings.

The Sethite View

This view is a Christian interpretation that dates back to the 4th century C.E. It argues that the sons of God are the godly line of Seth, who worship the true God ([Gen. 4:26](#)) and are contrasted with the un-godly line of Cain. Genesis 5:1-5 portrays Adam as a "son of God," and so it is argued that the sons of God are in fact the sons of Adam through Seth. For more on this, see Augustine's *City of God*, book 4, chapter 23.

Problems: The Hebrew Bible attests the plural phrase "sons of *Elohim*" and its variations over eight times, and it is used specifically to refer to the divine council. The text is more likely contrasting a boundary violation between humans and *elohim*. Seth and Cain are not mentioned in Genesis 6:1-4, nor is there any reference to intermarriage prohibitions between two human families.

The Divinized Human Rulers View

This modern view appeals to texts where human rulers are put on analogy with the divine. For example, when someone from the line of David is adopted as a "son of *Elohim*" (see [Ps. 2:7](#)), or when God's covenant people Israel are called Yahweh's "firstborn son" ([Exod. 4:23](#)). In this view, Genesis 6:1-4 is about human rulers who abused their divinely appointed role and engaged in polygamous marriages. For more information, see Meredith Kline, "Divine Kingship and Genesis 6:1-4."

Problems: Genesis 6:1-2 nowhere says that the marriages were polygamous. And while there are ancient Near Eastern parallels to divine kings as the son of a god, there is no parallel to an entire group or nation that is called "God's son" like Israel is ([Exod. 4:23](#)). The plural phrase "sons of *Elohim*" in biblical Hebrew refers uniquely to spiritual beings.

Conclusion: The most compelling explanation of the words used in Genesis 6:14 is that spiritual beings have abandoned the heavenly realm and invaded the human realm.

Reflection Question

Who or what are the sons of *Elohim*?

Session 9: The Identity of the Nephilim

Key Takeaways

- 120 years is how long it is until the flood comes. This is how long Noah will be having this dialogue with God as he builds his divinely provided refuge.
- Nephilim translates to “the fallen ones,” as in those who fall in battle. Ancient Israel’s neighbors celebrated those who won glory through conquest in battle. The Gibborim and Nephilim were heroes to the Babylonians and Canaanites, but the biblical authors see their violence as everything that is wrong with the human family.
- Genesis 6:4 is the origin story of the warrior giants the Israelites must face as they enter and occupy Canaan. These giants fill the narrative slot of the seed of the snake in the unfolding drama of the Hebrew Bible.

Did the Sons of *Elohim* Actually Have Sex With Human Women?

The plain sense meaning of this story is fairly clear: Yes, these spiritual beings crossed the Heaven and Earth boundary and had sex with women.

The phrase “and they took women for themselves” is a standard biblical Hebrew phrase for sexual intercourse, including illicit sex (see [Gen. 38:2](#); [Lev. 18:17](#), [20:17](#)).

When spiritual beings are sent on missions in the earthly realm, they are called by a functional title, *malakim* in Hebrew and in Greek, *angelos*, that is, “angels.” In the story of the Bible, angels regularly take on a human appearance and interact with humans in a physical way. They can walk with people, have meals (see [Gen. 18:1-5](#)), and wrestle with them as well (see [Gen. 32:23-32](#)).

This cosmic cross-species sexual encounter is reinforced by the presence of a narrative design pattern used by the author, who connects Genesis 6:1-4 with Genesis 3:1-7.

Genesis 2-3: The Snake and the Woman

Genesis 3:6 NASB*

And the woman saw (ראה) that the tree was good (טוב) for eating and **that (כי)** it was enticing to the eyes and it was desirable for gaining wisdom **and she took (לקח)** its fruit and she ate and she gave to her husband with her and he ate.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 2:24 NASB*

Therefore a man will leave his father and his mother and cling to his wife and they will become one **flesh** (בשר).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:1-14: The Sons of God and Human Women

Genesis 6:1-2 NASB*

¹ And it came about when humanity began to multiply on the face of the land ... ² and **the sons of God saw** (ראה), the daughters of humanity (בנות האדם) **that** (כי) they **were good** (טוב), and **they took** (לקח) for themselves wives from all which they chose.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 6:3 NASB*

And Yahweh said, "My Spirit will not dwell with humanity forever, in as much as he also is **flesh** (בשר), and his days will be one hundred and twenty years.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The action of the sons of God is portrayed as an intensified inversion of the garden story. Instead of the woman taking what is good in her own eyes because of the deception of a spiritual being, in Genesis 6, it is rebel spiritual beings who take women who are good in their eyes.

The analogy, which is intended by the author, also prompts us to consider the motive of the sons of God in light of the woman's motive. The woman desired to have divine wisdom and life in the garden on her own terms instead of honoring the creator's command. This prompts the reader to consider the unstated motive of the sons of God in Genesis 6:1-2. If they are set on analogy with the woman, we are encouraged to see their "taking women" as a move to restore the life of Eden to humanity, in opposition to God's command to exile them from access to the tree of life.

Later in Genesis 19, we find a narrative designed on analogy with Genesis 3 and 6:1-4. In the story of Lot's hosting the two angels in Sodom, the men of Sodom come to Lot's house in order to gang rape the "men" (the angels). And Lot, in a horrifying act of betrayal, offers his daughters to the crowd of men instead of the angels. In contrast to the corrupt sons of God who take the daughters of men, here a man offers his own daughters in the place of two sons of God. In Lot's case, the angels intervene and strike all the men of Sodom with blindness. The intended analogy sets up a contrast: It shows just how corrupt humanity has become once again, presenting Lot as the opposite of Abraham and Noah.

Genesis 6:1-4

- The sons of God visit human daughters
- The sons of God have sex with them

Genesis 19

- The men of Sodom want to have sex with the sons of God who visit Sodom
- Lot offers his daughters for sex

Comparing the Sons of God with the Men of Sodom. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Genesis 6:1-4	Genesis 19
• God rescues Noah and his sons • The land is destroyed by water from the sky	• Angels rescue Lot and his daughters • The city is destroyed by fire from the sky
<i>Comparing the Sons of God with the Men of Sodom.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

How Is Genesis 6:3 a Response to the Rebellion of Spiritual Beings?

Genesis 6:3 NASB*

And Yahweh said,

- (a) "My Spirit/breath will not dwell with the human forever,
 (b) because he too is flesh,
 (c) and so his days will be one hundred and twenty years."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"My Spirit/breath will not dwell forever"

This line recalls two earlier moments in Genesis 1-3.

In Genesis 2:7, humanity is animated by God's "breath of life." It is only by God's gift of life-energy that human existence is possible.

In Genesis 2:9 and 3:22, God wants humans to eat from the tree that unites them with God's own eternal life. However, once humans have rebelled, he exiles them from access to his eternal life presence. Here in Genesis 6:3, spiritual beings have rebelled by uniting with human women, and God's words reveal the motive: to restore eternal life to the rebellious human family! God is here saying that these illicit unions will not generate eternal life but will end in the same fate as the foolish humans in Genesis 3:22-24.

"Will not dwell (*yadon*) with the human"

The Hebrew word *yadon* (יָדֹן) occurs only here in ancient biblical Hebrew. There have been multiple proposals about its meaning based on Semitic languages that are related to Hebrew.

- "Judge, condemn" (related to Hebrew: *duwn* / דָּוָן) [adopted by the NIV as "contend"]
- "Strive, struggle" (NASB, KJV)

All of these proposals have been scrutinized and have no real evidence (see John Day, "The Sons of God and the Daughters of Men and the Giants," p. 87-89)

This verb almost certainly comes from a Semitic root *danan* (דָּנַן) "to remain, abide with" (see Umberto Cassuto, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis (Part I): From Adam to Noah*, 296). This is how the earliest translators of the Hebrew Bible into Greek understood the verb.